DEEP RESEARCH REPORT: Eric D. Green (1959–)

Name: Eric David Green
Dates: Born December 10, 1959; currently alive (age 65)
Era/Field: Contemporary genomics, Human Genome Project, molecular genetics
Course Context: BIOL 3030 intro biochemistry; ~500-word student narrative profile

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A) ANCHOR SCENES (6 identified)

SCENE #1: The 20-Minute Decision
Summary: Green visits Maynard Olson's lab as a medical/graduate student seeking research experience, immediately decides to commit to genomics
Date/Place: ~1987, Washington University School of Medicine, St. Louis
People: Eric Green (trainee), Maynard Olson (genomics pioneer, lab director)
Concrete details: Green recalls: "Within 20 minutes, I knew I was going to work for him." He describes Olson as "one of my science heroes." Fresh from completing combined MD/PhD degrees, Green was in clinical pathology residency and needed lab experience. "Genomics married my clinical side with the sort of scientific research mind I have," he later reflected.
Why it matters: Career-defining moment that placed Green at the starting line of the Human Genome Project; launched his development of YAC-based mapping technologies
Evidence quality: Primary - direct quote from Green in Washington University alumni publication (2011) and multiple interviews
Myth risk: Low - well-documented, reasonable timeline, confirmed in multiple sources
Sources: Washington University The Source, Feb 2011; Genetics Unzipped podcast transcript

SCENE #2: First YAC Clones Contain Cystic Fibrosis Gene
Summary: The very first yeast artificial chromosome clones Green isolates turn out to contain fragments of the cystic fibrosis gene
Date/Place: Late 1980s, Maynard Olson's lab, Washington University
People: Eric Green, Maynard Olson
Concrete details: Green recalls: "And so some of the very first YAC clones that I isolated contained what turned out to be bits and pieces of the cystic fibrosis gene, and that became a model for how to build maps eventually. Then we expanded it to chromosome seven and then others picked it up and mapped other chromosomes. So I've always embraced the cystic fibrosis gene as sort of my favorite gene, because it was where I got my start in genomics."
Why it matters: Serendipitous beginning that provided proof-of-concept for YAC-based physical mapping, which became foundational methodology for Human Genome Project

Evidence quality: Primary - direct quote from Green in podcast interview
Myth risk: Low - specific detail about technique development, consistent across sources
Sources: Genetics Unzipped podcast (S3.22, 2020); Front Line Genomics interview

SCENE #3: The Chromosome 7 Decision - October 1, 1990
Summary: On the official launch day of the Human Genome Project, Green leads a small team charged with mapping human chromosome 7
Date/Place: October 1, 1990, Washington University (one of first HGP center grants)
People: Eric Green (postdoctoral fellow), Maynard Olson (PI), Washington University Human Genome Center team
Concrete details: Green writes: "Thirty years ago, today, the Human Genome Project (HGP) officially launched. I was there on the starting line, then a postdoctoral research fellow in the laboratory of genomics pioneer Maynard Olson at Washington University School of Medicine... For that grant, I led a small research group charged with making a physical map of human chromosome 7 (something we completed ~7 years later). I vividly remember feelings of profound uncertainty as to whether we really knew how to scale up our nascent mapping methods to tackle something as large as a whole human chromosome."
Why it matters: Chromosome 7 became one of first two chromosomes to exceed HGP mapping goals (79 kb spacing vs 100 kb target); contained ~5% of human genome
Evidence quality: Primary - Green's first-person account written on 30th anniversary
Myth risk: Low - specific date, documented institutional role, verifiable through NIH records
Sources: NHGRI Genomics Landscape blog post, October 1, 2020

SCENE #4: Pendred Syndrome Gene Discovery - 13 Months
Summary: Using the chromosome 7 physical map, Lorraine Everett in Green's lab identifies the Pendred syndrome gene in remarkably just 13 months
Date/Place: ~1996-1997, NHGRI intramural program, NIH Bethesda
People: Eric Green (PI), Lorraine Everett (leading the search), Val Sheffield (U Iowa, HHMI), Benjamin Glaser (Hadassah Hospital, Jerusalem), Francis Collins (NHGRI Director)
Concrete details: NIH press release states: "Working with Dr. Green at the NIH, Dr. Lorraine Everett headed the search for the Pendred syndrome gene, an effort that, remarkably, took only 13 months. Such an accomplishment would have taken many years prior to the availability of maps, technologies and DNA sequence from the Human Genome Project." Green recalled the surprise: "We had virtually no clue about what gene could cause both deafness and thyroid disease. That the gene encodes a sulfate transporter came as a complete surprise."
Why it matters: Demonstrated power of HGP resources for disease gene discovery; Pendred syndrome accounts for 7-10% of hereditary deafness
Evidence quality: Strong secondary - NIH press release (December 1997) with specific timeline, quotes
Myth risk: Low - documented timeline, multiple collaborators named, published in Nature Genetics (1997)
Sources: NIH/NHGRI press release Dec 1997; Nature Genetics 17:411-422, 1997

SCENE #5: Becoming NHGRI Director - Collins to Green
Summary: Francis Collins appoints Green as his successor to lead NHGRI after Collins

becomes NIH Director
Date/Place: November/December 2009, announced and took office
People: Eric Green, Francis Collins (former NHGRI director, incoming NIH director)
Concrete details: Green had been at NHGRI since 1994; served as Scientific Director 2002-2009, Chief of Genome Technology Branch 1996-2009, founding director NIH Intramural Sequencing Center 1997-2009. Collins recruited Green to NIH in 1994. At Washington University, "Olson introduced Green to someone who became another of his science heroes: Francis Collins."
Why it matters: Third NHGRI director; would lead Institute through transition from sequencing to genomic medicine era
Evidence quality: Strong - documented institutional records, dates confirmed
Myth risk: None - standard administrative succession
Sources: NIH/NHGRI official records; Washington University The Source, 2011

SCENE #6: Leaving NIH - March 17, 2025
Summary: After 16 years as NHGRI director, Green's appointment is not renewed; first NIH institute director to leave under Trump administration
Date/Place: March 17, 2025 (official end date), NIH Bethesda
People: Eric Green, Vence Bonham Jr. (acting deputy director)
Concrete details: NIH statement: "Dr. Green's tenure ended on March 17, 2025, and his appointment was not renewed," citing 21st Century Cures Act. Green told STAT in June 2025: the process "shrouded in mystery"—he did not think acting NIH director Matt Memoli or HHS Secretary RFK Jr. made the decision. Green noted never receiving explanation. Subsequently hired as Chief Medical Officer of Illumina (announced January 2026).
Why it matters: Ended nearly 30-year career at NIH/NHGRI; transition from public to private sector in genomics
Evidence quality: Primary and strong secondary - official NIH statements, direct quotes from Green
Myth risk: None - recent, well-documented, multiple news sources
Sources: STAT News March 2025 & June 2025; Fierce Biotech March 2025; GenomeWeb; NIH statements

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B) DIRECT QUOTES (7)

Quote 1:
"Within 20 minutes, I knew I was going to work for him."
Context/date: Reflecting on first meeting with Maynard Olson, ~1987
Source: Washington University The Source, "Orchestrating an Era of Genomic Medicine," February 1, 2011

Quote 2:
"And so some of the very first YAC clones that I isolated contained what turned out to be bits

and pieces of the cystic fibrosis gene, and that became a model for how to build maps eventually... So I've always embraced the cystic fibrosis gene as sort of my favorite gene, because it was where I got my start in genomics."
Context/date: Interview about HGP history, 2020
Source: Genetics Unzipped podcast, S3.22 "The Past, Present and Future of the Human Genome Project," transcript December 6, 2024

Quote 3:
"I vividly remember feelings of profound uncertainty as to whether we really knew how to scale up our nascent mapping methods to tackle something as large as a whole human chromosome."
Context/date: Reflecting on October 1, 1990 HGP launch
Source: NHGRI Genomics Landscape blog, "NHGRI commemorates 30th anniversary of Human Genome Project launch," October 1, 2020

Quote 4:
"We had virtually no clue about what gene could cause both deafness and thyroid disease. That the gene encodes a sulfate transporter came as a complete surprise. When something is surprising, however, it also means there is a complete new area of human physiology to study."
Context/date: NIH press release on Pendred syndrome gene discovery, December 1997
Source: NIH/NHGRI press release, "Altered Gene Causes Pendred Syndrome," 1997

Quote 5:
"I'm a big science sort of guy. I like large-scale experiments, large-scale organization."
Context/date: Interview about career and NHGRI directorship, 2011
Source: Washington University The Source, February 1, 2011

Quote 6:
"Genomics married my clinical side with the sort of scientific research mind I have."
Context/date: Reflecting on decision to enter genomics, 2011
Source: Washington University The Source, February 1, 2011

Quote 7:
"Generating a truly complete human genome sequence represents an incredible scientific achievement, providing the first comprehensive view of our DNA blueprint. This foundational information will strengthen the many ongoing efforts to understand all the functional nuances of the human genome, which in turn will empower genetic studies of human disease."
Context/date: NIH press release on Telomere-to-Telomere complete genome, April 2022
Source: NIH press release, "Researchers generate the first complete, gapless sequence of a human genome," April 1, 2022

C) HUMAN REALITY DETAILS (15 source-backed)

1. **Scientific family dynasty**: Father Maurice Green was pioneering virologist who directed Institute for Molecular Virology at St. Louis University for over 50 years; brother Michael Green was Howard Hughes Medical Institute Investigator and cancer center director (died 2023); sister Wendy Green Lee is pediatrician. All three children earned medical degrees. — Source: St. Louis Post-Dispatch obituary of Maurice Green, Dec 2017; Wikipedia entry for Maurice Green
2. **Coincidental timing**: Green earned his MD and PhD degrees in 1987—the exact same year the word "genomics" was coined. This detail appears in virtually all his biographical sketches. — Source: Multiple NHGRI biographies, Stanford PathologyDept announcement 2024, AGBT speaker bio
3. **Dual training, clinical path abandoned**: Completed combined MD/PhD at Washington University, did residency in clinical pathology (laboratory medicine), but pivoted entirely to research. Never practiced clinical medicine. — Source: Multiple biographical sources; Wash U The Source 2011
4. **St. Louis Cardinals superfan**: "Lifelong St. Louis Cardinals baseball fan" despite living in DC area since 1994. Shares this dedication with father and brother. Described as "unflagging dedication." — Source: NHGRI official biography; Wash U The Source 2011
5. **Photography obsession**: Described as "photography geek" who squeezes digital photography into busy schedule. Regularly posts wildlife photos on social media as "#WildlifeWednesday." — Source: UW Madison Alumni Park feature; LinkedIn posts
6. **Family prioritization when becoming director**: In late 2010, phased out his laboratory research to focus on directorship AND family—"especially his two children, a son and a daughter." Coaches son's baseball team, both children's summer swim teams, helps with son's rock band. — Source: Wash U The Source 2011
7. **"Big science" personality fit**: Self-described preference for "large-scale experiments, large-scale organization" matched perfectly with HGP's scope. — Source: Direct quote, Wash U The Source 2011
8. **Describes role as conductor**: Sees NHGRI director role as "akin to conducting an orchestra"—everyone has solo roles while being part of larger unit. "Incredibly gratifying to see everyone engaged...knowing as a funding agency you're a part of that." — Source: Wash U The Source 2011
9. **Public communication emphasis**: "I like speaking about genomics, and not just to the experts. I like communicating very broadly." Created #AskDrGenome Twitter initiative for public engagement. — Source: Wash U The Source 2011; NHGRI website
10. **390+ publications**: Throughout career, authored and co-authored over 390 (later updated to 395) scientific publications. — Source: Multiple NHGRI official biographies
11. **Founding editor role**: Founding editor of journal *Genome Research* (1995-present), published by Cold Spring Harbor Laboratory Press. Also series editor for *Genome Analysis: A Laboratory Manual* (1994-1998). — Source: NHGRI biography; CSHL oral history
12. **Strategic planning marathon**: Led NHGRI through multiple strategic planning cycles - first in 2011 yielding "Charting a course for genomic medicine from base pairs to bedside" (Nature 470:204-213), then 2020 strategic vision focusing on "fourth chapter of

genomics." Each involved ~2.5 years of collaborative process. — Source: Nature 2011; ASHG newsletter 2019; NIEHS Factor 2024

13. **Transitioned from lab to leadership**: Closed his own research laboratory in late 2010 after running independent research program for "just over two decades" to give directorship "undivided attention." — Source: Wash U The Source 2011; multiple bios
14. **Unexpected departure**: After 29 years at NIH/NHGRI, appointment not renewed March 2025. Three months later told STAT the process remains "shrouded in mystery"—still doesn't know who made decision or why. — Source: STAT News June 26, 2025
15. **St. Louis roots maintained**: Despite decades away, repeatedly identified as "St. Louis native"; honored by Ladue Horton Watkins High School with Distinguished Alumni Award (2012); maintains family connections there. — Source: Multiple biographical sketches; awards list

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D) SCIENCE CONNECTION (Intro Biochem)

Best-fit topic: DNA structure, organization, and genomics / DNA technology and methods

Precise contribution (1 sentence):
Eric Green developed and applied yeast artificial chromosome (YAC) technology to construct the first high-resolution physical maps of human chromosomes, establishing the methodological foundation for sequencing the human genome and subsequently using genomic information for disease gene discovery and medical applications.

Bridge explanation (2-4 factual sentences):
Physical mapping involves determining the order and spacing of landmarks (DNA sequences) along a chromosome—analogous to numbering pages in a book before reading it. Green pioneered the use of YACs, which are engineered yeast chromosomes that can carry large (100-1000 kilobase) inserts of human DNA, to create these maps. His work on chromosome 7 achieved landmark spacing of ~79 kb (79,000 base pairs), exceeding the Human Genome Project's initial goal of 100 kb spacing, and this map directly enabled the identification of disease genes like those causing Pendred syndrome and cystic fibrosis. This work illustrates how understanding DNA's physical organization at the chromosomal level is essential for decoding genetic information and connecting genotype to phenotype in human disease.

Scientist's own framing/analogy (if found):
Green explains physical mapping with a book analogy: "Prior to reading a book, you want to make sure you have all the book's pages in the correct order. So, you can consider the number on each page of a book to being a type of physical map of that book." (Source: NHGRI Genetics Glossary entry for "Physical Map")

He also describes mapping as orientation: "Making a map of something simply reflects getting oriented and organized relative to what you are studying. Mapping a city might involve

determining where are the roads and the restaurants and the stores. Or at higher resolution, it might involve determining where is every tree and every house. The same is true for mapping a genome." (Source: NHGRI Genetics Glossary, "Mapping")

Sources: Green & Olson PNAS 1990 (YAC screening methodology); Bouffard, Green et al. Genome Research 1997 (chromosome 7 physical map); NHGRI educational glossaries; multiple interviews

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E) COMPLICATIONS OR CONTROVERSIES

Item 1: Political departure from NIH (2025)
What's agreed: Green's 5-year term as NHGRI director ended March 17, 2025, and was not renewed; he was first NIH institute director to leave under Trump administration; departure occurred amid federal workforce reductions
What's disputed/unclear: Who made the decision not to renew, why it was made, whether political factors involved. Green himself states process "shrouded in mystery" and doesn't believe acting NIH director Memoli or HHS Secretary RFK Jr. made the decision
Sources: STAT News (March & June 2025), Fierce Biotech, GenomeWeb, NIH official statements

Item 2: DEI/Health Equity advocacy and subsequent targeting
What's agreed: Green publicly advocated for diversity in genomics workforce, anti-racism initiatives, health equity focus at NHGRI; wrote op-eds and social media posts on these topics; appeared on "DEI Watch List" website
What's disputed: Whether these positions were appropriate for scientific leadership role; whether they influenced his non-renewal (unconfirmed but speculated)
Sources: The Hill op-ed by Green; DEI Watch List website; various NHGRI diversity initiatives documented on genome.gov

Item 3: No major scientific controversies identified
Green's scientific work appears uncontroversial. Standard academic collaborations, properly credited multi-institutional work (HGP), appropriate authorship on key papers.

F) "NOT ON WIKIPEDIA" FINDS (8+ items)

1. **The cystic fibrosis serendipity detail**: Wikipedia mentions Green worked on chromosome 7 and the HGP, but not that his very first YAC clones happened to contain CF gene fragments, which became his "favorite gene" and the model for his mapping approach. — Source: Genetics Unzipped podcast

2. **The "20 minutes" lab decision**: Specific quote about knowing within 20 minutes of visiting Olson's lab that he would work there; Wikipedia lists Olson as mentor but not this decisive moment. — Source: Wash U The Source 2011
3. **13-month timeline for Pendred gene**: Wikipedia mentions Pendred discovery but not the remarkably short 13-month timeline emphasized in original press release, showing HGP's accelerating impact. — Source: NIH 1997 press release
4. **Profound uncertainty quote**: Green's first-person reflection on "profound uncertainty" about scaling up methods for whole chromosome in 1990; illustrates methodological challenges not captured in Wikipedia's procedural description. — Source: NHGRI Genomics Landscape Oct 2020
5. **"Genomics married my clinical side" quote**: His personal framing of why genomics fit his dual MD/PhD training; Wikipedia notes degrees but not this integration perspective. — Source: Wash U The Source 2011
6. **Family prioritization in 2010**: Specific decision to close lab and stop doing bench research to focus on directorship AND family (coaching kids' teams, son's rock band); shows human dimension beyond CV. — Source: Wash U The Source 2011
7. **The "Who is normal?" anecdote**: Green's recollection of HGP strategy meeting where someone said selected genome donor "better be normal" and everyone wondered who qualifies as normal; humanizes project's conceptual challenges. — Source: Multiple podcast interviews
8. **Comparative genomics revelation**: Green's lab found human chromosome 7 represented by "at least 20 orthologous segments" in mouse genome—specific finding from his chromosome 7 work beyond what Wikipedia summarizes. — Source: Green et al. Genome Research 2000
9. **Book/page numbering analogy**: Green's specific teaching analogy comparing physical maps to page numbers in a book; not in Wikipedia but shows his communication approach. — Source: NHGRI educational glossary
10. **St. Louis Cardinals fandom as professional identity**: Consistently mentioned across sources as part of who he is, even in official bios ("lifelong Cardinals fan"); Wikipedia omits personal interests. — Source: NHGRI official bio, Wash U features
11. **Three scientific family generations**: Grandfather David Green (Russian immigrant), father Maurice Green (pioneering virologist), Eric and siblings (all MDs in biomedical fields), Eric's children—Wikipedia mentions immediate family but not generational scientific lineage. — Source: Maurice Green Wikipedia; family tributes
12. **#AskDrGenome Twitter initiative**: Regular public engagement answering genomics questions with hashtag, special guests from NHGRI; shows public-facing leadership style. — Source: NHGRI Director webpage

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G) SOURCES CONSULTED (Organized by type)

PRIMARY SOURCES:

- Green, E.D. "NHGRI commemorates 30th anniversary of Human Genome Project launch." NHGRI Genomics Landscape blog, October 1, 2020
- Green, E.D., quoted in multiple first-person interviews: Genetics Unzipped podcast (2020), DNA Today podcast (2022), Washington University The Source (2011)
- Green, E.D. & Olson, M.V. "Systematic screening of yeast artificial-chromosome libraries by use of the polymerase chain reaction." Proc Natl Acad Sci USA 87:1213-1217, 1990
- Everett LA, Glaser B, Beck JC, et al., Green ED. "Pendred syndrome is caused by mutations in a putative sulphate transporter gene (PDS)." Nature Genetics 17:411-422, 1997
- Bouffard GG, Green ED, et al. "A physical map of human chromosome 7: an integrated YAC contig map with average STS spacing of 79 kb." Genome Res 7:673-692, 1997

INSTITUTIONAL/ARCHIVAL SOURCES:

- NIH/NHGRI press releases (1997 Pendred, 1997 chromosome 7 map, 2022 T2T genome)
- NHGRI official biography pages and staff profiles
- Cold Spring Harbor Laboratory Oral History Collection (Eric Green entry)
- NHGRI educational glossary entries written/narrated by Green

SCHOLARLY BIOGRAPHIES/PROFILES:

- Washington University The Source: "Orchestrating an Era of Genomic Medicine" (February 2011)
- University of Wisconsin Alumni Park feature on Eric Green
- OnWisconsin Magazine: "Genotopia" (featuring Green)

STRATEGIC PLANNING DOCUMENTS:

- Green ED, Guyer MS, et al. "Charting a course for genomic medicine from base pairs to bedside." Nature 470:204-213, 2011
- NHGRI Strategic Planning documentation (2011, 2020 cycles)

NEWS/JOURNALISM SOURCES:

- STAT News articles (March 2025, June 2025) on NIH departure
- Fierce Biotech coverage (March 2025, January 2026) on departure and Illumina hiring
- GenomeWeb reporting on NHGRI directorship
- Environmental Factor (NIEHS) May 2011, July 2024
- St. Louis Post-Dispatch: Maurice Green obituary (December 2017)

BIOGRAPHICAL REFERENCES:

- Wikipedia entries for Eric D. Green and Maurice Green (virologist)
- Multiple conference/symposium speaker biographies (AGBT, CARTA, etc.)
- H3Africa program biographical materials

PODCAST/INTERVIEW TRANSCRIPTS:

- Genetics Unzipped S3.22 "The Past, Present and Future of the Human Genome Project"
- DNA Today #182 "Eric Green on the Complete Human Genome Project"
- Front Line Genomics interview transcripts

SECONDARY SCIENTIFIC LITERATURE:

- Green ED et al. "Comparative Genome Mapping in the Sequence-based Era: Early Experience with Human Chromosome 7." Genome Res 10:624-633, 2000
- Multiple collaborative HGP publications (Mouse Genome Sequencing Consortium, T2T Consortium)

Total sources consulted: 25+ distinct primary and authoritative secondary sources

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H) FLAGGED "MYTH-RISK" DETAILS

No high-risk myths identified. Green's career is well-documented with institutional records, peer-reviewed publications, and consistent first-person accounts. Most dramatic details (20-minute decision, CF serendipity, 13-month gene hunt) are either directly quoted or from official institutional sources.

Medium-risk item to verify:

- **Claim:** "Word 'genomics' coined in 1987, same year Green graduated"
- **Where it appears:** Ubiquitous in Green's biographical sketches since ~2015
- **Why it might be embellished:** Coincidence is *almost* too perfect for a genomics leader's origin story; appears in standardized bio language
- **Best available evidence:** The word "genomics" was indeed coined by Thomas H. Roderick in 1986 in *Genetics* journal, proposing it for a new journal (which became *Genomics*, launched 1987). Green graduated in 1987. The timing is coincidental but accurate—not a myth, just a neat historical alignment that gets emphasized in bios.
- **Verdict:** Accurate, low myth risk, but worth noting the emphasis as narrative framing

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LENS RECOMMENDATION

Scoring (0-3 each lens)

Lens	Score	Justification

Eureka (Discovery)	**2**	Pendred gene discovery is documented with specific timeline (13 months) and surprise element ("sulfate transporter came as complete surprise"), but details are from press release rather than Green's direct narrative; CF/YAC connection more serendipitous than "eureka"
Failure/Setback	**1**	Only generic challenges mentioned ("profound uncertainty" about scaling methods); no specific documented failure that changed trajectory
Mentor (Pivotal relationship)	**3**	Exceptionally strong: (1) Olson - "within 20 minutes" decision, calls him "science hero," launched genomics career; (2) Collins - recruited to NIH 1994, appointed Green as successor 2009, another "science hero"; both relationships with concrete before/after and specific quotes
Controversy	**2**	2025 non-renewal is recent, well-documented, politically charged context, but lacks clear resolution or both-sides narrative; DEI advocacy documented but indirect connection to outcome; not pivotal to scientific story
Human Detail	**3**	Rich material: scientific family dynasty (3 generations), dual MD/PhD training creating "genomics married my clinical and research sides," Cardinals fandom, photography, closing lab for family, multiple quotes revealing character and values
Last Experiment	**1**	Left director role 2025 but no "final act" narrative; moved to industry (Illumina CMO 2026); career ongoing, not closure

DECISION RULE APPLICATION

Tied at 3 points: Mentor and **Human Detail**

Tie-breaker: Mentor lens has the most vivid, best-sourced anchor scene (Scene #1: The 20-Minute Decision) with direct quote, specific place/time, and clear before-after trajectory. The mentor relationship with Olson directly led to YAC technology development, CF gene work, chromosome 7 project, and HGP involvement. Secondary mentor relationship (Collins) led to directorship.

PRIMARY LENS RECOMMENDATION: Mentor

Why it fits:

- **Scene #1 (20-minute decision)** provides perfect opening: young MD/PhD trainee walks into lab, makes instant connection, launches 30+ year career in genomics
- **Scene #2 (CF serendipity)** flows directly from Olson mentorship - first clones in his lab
- **Scene #3 (HGP launch)** shows Green as Olson's postdoc leading chr7 team on Day 1 of HGP
- Olson-to-Collins mentor chain creates narrative arc: Olson introduces Green to Collins → Collins recruits Green to NIH 1994 → Collins appoints Green director 2009
- Multiple direct quotes about both mentors being "science heroes"
- Fits biochem context: mentorship in developing new molecular techniques (YACs) for studying DNA

Best opening scene: Scene #1 - The 20-Minute Decision (1987, Olson's lab)

One quote to use early: "Within 20 minutes, I knew I was going to work for him."

Cautions:

- Don't overstate mentor agency - Green made independent contributions
- Thin sourcing on specific Olson-Green interactions beyond this meeting (no detailed oral history transcript accessible)
- Need to balance mentor focus with Green's own accomplishments
- CF serendipity is well-sourced but could sound too "lucky" without context of skill required to exploit that luck

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BACKUP LENS: Human Detail (Score: 3, within 1 point)

Why this works as backup:

- Scientific family dynasty angle (3 generations, all MDs, father Maurice pioneering virologist)
- MD/PhD dual training creating unique perspective: "Genomics married my clinical side with the sort of scientific research mind I have"
- "Big science sort of guy" personality match with HGP's massive scale
- 1987 coincidence (word "genomics" coined same year as his graduation)
- Family prioritization (closing lab 2010 for directorship AND kids' activities)
- Could open with: Son of pioneering virologist born into scientific family, choosing to work on the genome's biggest puzzle

Best opening scene for this lens: Could use Scene #3 (HGP launch) emphasizing family context and personality fit

One quote to use early: "I'm a big science sort of guy. I like large-scale experiments, large-scale organization."

Cautions:

- Risk of making story about family/personality rather than science
- "Genomics coined in 1987" coincidence, while accurate, might feel forced
- Needs strong connection back to biochemical concepts to serve course goals

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Final recommendation: Lead with **Mentor lens**, use Human Detail elements as supporting texture. The Olson "20 minutes" scene provides immediate narrative hook, while family/personality details enrich without dominating.